

SANTO DOMINGO

A practical 7-day guide

12-18 September 2026 · based at Crowne Plaza Santo Domingo · working days, free after 18:00

Quick read: hot, humid and intermittently wet; Uber is available; internet is generally good; use authorised transport at night; drink bottled/purified water; spend your free weekend time in the Colonial Zone and Los Tres Ojos.

Money shortcut: using your working rate of about RD\$73 = £1, divide pesos by 73. RD\$100 ≈ £1.37; RD\$500 ≈ £6.85; RD\$1,000 ≈ £13.70.

Hotel: Crowne Plaza Santo Domingo, Av. George Washington 218, Malecón.

Keep this PDF offline. Prices are practical estimates, not promises. Event listings and weather checked 11 Sep 2026.

1. Weather & what to pack

Expect 32-34°C by day and 23-24°C overnight. The forecast for your stay is mostly sun/cloud with short showers, especially afternoons; Thursday-Friday look wetter. Humidity will make it feel hotter. September is within Atlantic hurricane season, so check the forecast each morning.

Date	Forecast	High / low
Sat 12	Hazy sun; spot afternoon shower	34 / 24°C
Sun 13	Broken cloud; some afternoon rain	34 / 24°C
Mon 14	Sun → cloud; little afternoon rain	33 / 24°C
Tue 15	Partly sunny; brief shower or two	32 / 23°C
Wed 16	Sunny periods	32 / 23°C
Thu 17	Showers; rain periods afternoon	32 / 23°C
Fri 18	Cloudier; a few showers	34 / 23°C

Pack / carry

- Lightweight shirts/trousers; one smart-casual evening outfit. Air-conditioning can be aggressive, so one very light layer.
- Small umbrella or packable rain shell. Showers can be abrupt rather than all-day.
- SPF, sunglasses and insect repellent. Dengue is present and the vector bites in daytime.
- Refillable bottle is fine, but fill it with purified/bottled water - tap water is not considered drinkable.
- Comfortable shoes for the Colonial Zone's stone streets.

No malaria risk is identified for Santo Domingo itself in current UK guidance, but mosquito-bite avoidance still matters because of dengue.

2. Airport → Crowne Plaza

SDQ (Las Américas) is roughly 30 km east of central Santo Domingo. In ordinary traffic, think roughly 35-50 minutes; rush-hour traffic can make it longer.

Lowest-hassle legitimate taxi: after arrivals, go to the SICHALA authorised taxi stand at the main entrance on Level 1. SICHALA is the airport-authorised operator. Do not accept an unsolicited ride from someone approaching you in the terminal.

- Tell them: Crowne Plaza Santo Domingo, Avenida George Washington 218.

- Confirm the fare before getting in. SICHALA currently publishes about US\$35 to Santo Domingo / US\$40 to Distrito Nacional for advance reservations; walk-up can vary slightly.
- SICHALA airport numbers: +1 809 549 0245 / 0011 / 0364. WhatsApp: +1 829 280 6819.
- Uber also operates at SDQ. Request only in the app, follow its pickup directions and verify name, registration and vehicle.
- For the first arrival with luggage, the authorised airport taxi is simplest. In the city, Uber is usually the convenient default.

FCDO advice is to use authorised airport/hotel taxis or registered ride-hailing rather than street pickups.

3. What to see while anchored to the city

Best use of your weekend / daylight

- Zona Colonial: essential. Walk Calle Las Damas, Parque Colón, Catedral Primada de América, Fortaleza Ozama, Plaza de España and the riverfront. Allow half a day.
- Alcázar de Colón + Museo de las Casas Reales: worthwhile for historical context. Do these while museums are open.
- Los Tres Ojos: limestone cave/lake system inside the city. Go in daylight; Uber both ways.
- Malecón: you are staying on it. Good for sea air and sunset, but treat it as an urban waterfront rather than a carefree late-night promenade.
- Plaza de la Cultura: museums, Teatro Nacional and green space; useful if an event takes you there.

After work: realistic 18:00+ plan

- One evening: Uber to Parque Colón → stroll the lit Colonial Zone → dinner → Uber back.
- One evening: Plaza de España / Atarazana area → dinner at Mesón de Bari or nearby → drink in Zona Colonial.
- One evening: Teatro Nacional event → late dinner/drink.
- Easy evening: dinner in Gazcue near the hotel; no transport logistics.

Museums and formal attractions tend to be daytime activities, so save those for Saturday/Sunday. The Colonial Zone remains the best evening destination.

4. Eat & drink

Dominican things worth ordering

- La bandera: rice, beans and meat - everyday Dominican lunch.
- Sancocho: rich mixed-meat/root-vegetable stew.
- Mofongo: mashed fried plantain with garlic/chicharrón or seafood.
- Mangú: mashed green plantain, usually breakfast; 'los tres golpes' adds fried cheese, salami and egg.
- Chicharrón, yuca, tostones and pescado. Try fresh chinola (passionfruit) juice.

Drink

- Presidente beer: ubiquitous and usually served extremely cold.

- Rum: Brugal, Barceló and Bermúdez are the big Dominican names. For sipping, look for Brugal 1888 or Barceló Imperial rather than the cheapest mixing rum.
- Mamajuana: rum/wine/honey infused with bark and herbs. Try one.
- For rum, order it neat/on ice first. Resort-style cocktails can hide whether the rum is any good.

5. Eating near the Crowne Plaza

The hotel is on the Malecón at the southern edge of Gazcue. 'Near' means walkable/short Uber, plus a few Colonial Zone places worth the extra ride.

Place	Why go	Spend*
Villar Hermanos	Busy Dominican institution; easy casual local meal	RD\$500-1,000
El Conuco	Traditional Dominican; polished/touristy but useful first taste	RD\$500-2,500
Casa Gazcue	Well-rated neighbourhood option; contemporary	RD\$1,000-1,500
Restaurante Manolo	Reliable Dominican/Caribbean; broad menu, long hours	RD\$500-3,000
El Gallego	Strong Spanish option; seafood/meat; more formal	RD\$1,500-3,500
Boga Boga	Long-established Spanish restaurant; proper dinner	mid/high
Luna Tapas	On the Malecón; convenient low-logistics option	mid
Mesón de Bari	Classic Dominican/Caribbean; pair with Colonial Zone walk	mid
Jalao	Lively Dominican food/music atmosphere in Zona Colonial	RD\$1,000-3,500
Buche Perico	Attractive Colonial setting; nicer dinner	mid/high

*Current business-listing indicators where available, not fixed menu prices. Add drinks, tax/service and tourist-area unlift

Short list: Villar Hermanos for unfussy local food; El Conuco once for the classic Dominican experience; Mesón de Bari for a Colonial Zone evening; Boga Boga or El Gallego for a proper sit-down dinner.

6. Sensible price guide

Using ~RD\$73 = £1. Local food can be inexpensive; polished restaurants and hotel bars move quickly toward European prices.

Item	Expectation	Approx £
Local/inexpensive meal	RD\$400-750	£5.50-10
Mid-range dinner, one	RD\$1,200-2,500	£16-34
3-course for two, no drinks	~RD\$3,000	~£41
Local draft beer	RD\$120-300	£1.65-4.10
Imported beer	RD\$200-450	£2.75-6.15
Coffee/cappuccino	RD\$100-250	£1.40-3.40
Cocktail, decent bar	RD\$500-800	£7-11
1.5 L bottled water, shop	~RD\$60	<£1
Airport authorised taxi	US\$35-40-ish	~£26-30†

†USD→GBP deliberately approximate. Uber varies with traffic/demand. Food figures use May-Sep 2026 price datasets and current business listings.

7. Work, internet, VPN, money & local practicalities

Internet / VPN

- Internet is generally fine for work. Santo Domingo has fibre services in the hundreds of Mbps; recent city measurements put typical fixed broadband around ~79 Mbps down / 44 Mbps up.
- VPNs should work normally. There is no general national VPN block to plan around. With hotel Wi-Fi, complete any captive-portal sign-in first, then connect the VPN.
- Claro and Altice are the main practical network names. Mobile data is a sensible backup.

Money

- Dominican peso (RD\$/DOP) is the everyday currency. Carry some small notes; cards are common in hotels and better restaurants.
- Keep your card in sight when paying; FCDO specifically notes card-cloning/identity-theft risk.
- ATMs are preferable to changing large amounts of cash on the street. Decline GBP dynamic currency conversion if your bank's rate is better.

Language / rhythm

- Spanish dominates. Hotels/tourist venues often manage English; elsewhere a little Spanish helps.
- Dinner at 19:30-21:00 is normal.
- Traffic is the main time sink. Short map distances can take much longer at peak times.

8. What to avoid

Use urban-Caribbean street sense rather than European-city autopilot.

- Do not wander quiet streets or the Malecón alone late at night. Use Uber/hotel taxi door-to-door after dinner.
- Keep the phone discreet on the street. Motorcycle snatch theft is specifically flagged in current UK travel advice.
- Avoid displaying jewellery, carrying lots of cash, or leaving a phone/bag on a restaurant table or chair.
- Do not use motoconchos unless you actively accept the road-safety risk; helmets are not reliably provided.

- I would not hire a car for this trip. Traffic, driving standards and parking make Uber/taxis a better fit.
- Avoid the Haiti border region entirely; it is irrelevant to this city trip.
- Do not drink tap water. Use bottled/purified water.
- Do not ignore heavy-rain/tropical-storm alerts. September is hurricane season; localised flooding can occur.

If robbed, do not resist. Emergency number in Santo Domingo: 911. Tourist police (Politur): +1 809 200 3500.

9. Events during 12-18 September

The useful evening listings I found are more theatre/musical than major touring concerts. Re-check before travelling across town.

Date	Event	Venue / note
12-18 Sep	CHICAGO - El Musical	Teatro Nacional Eduardo Brito; run listed 12-19 Sep
12-13 Sep	Paradiso	Sala Manuel Rueda; run ends 13 Sep
17-18 Sep	Perdida Mente	Sala Ravelo, Teatro Nacional; comedy, run 17-19 Sep
18 Sep onward	Una Hora de Tranquilidad	Sala Manuel Rueda; starts 18 Sep

Best fit: CHICAGO at Teatro Nacional. I did not find a clearly compelling major concert in Santo Domingo during your exact 12-18 Sep window in the current main ticket listings.

10. A low-effort 7-day shape

Day	After work / free time
Sat 12	Arrival. Check in, easy Malecón/Gazcue dinner. Do not over-plan.
Sun 13	Daylight: Zona Colonial museums + streets. Evening: dinner/drink there.
Mon 14	18:30 Uber to Colonial Zone; Parque Colón → Plaza de España → Mesón de Bari.
Tue 15	Local night: Villar Hermanos or El Conuco; early night.
Wed 16	Teatro / CHICAGO if performance time suits; otherwise Zona Colonial.
Thu 17	Likely wetter: Boga Boga / El Gallego / hotel-adjacent dinner.
Fri 18	Final evening: Jalao/Buche Perico + one good rum; Uber home.

If you only manage three things: Zona Colonial in daylight, a proper Dominican meal, and an evening in the Colonial Zone. Los Tres Ojos is the best extra if you have a free 2-3 hour daylight block.

Sources checked 11 Sep 2026

UK FCDO - Dominican Republic safety, health and entry requirements

<https://www.gov.uk/foreign-travel-advice/dominican-republic>

Las Américas Airport - authorised taxi service

<https://aeropuertolasamericas.com/servicios-de-taxi/>

SICHALA - airport taxi tariffs

<https://sichala.com/tarifas/>

Uber - SDQ airport pickup

<https://www.uber.com/global/en/r/airports/sdq/pickup/>

Dominican Republic Tourism - Santo Domingo dining

<https://www.godominicanrepublic.com/things-to-do/santo-domingo-dining>

Teatro Nacional Eduardo Brito - programme

<https://teatronacional.gob.do/>

Uepa Tickets - Santo Domingo event listings

<https://uepatickets.com/tickets/en/principal>

Numbeo - Santo Domingo prices, updated May 2026

<https://www.numbeo.com/cost-of-living/in/Santo-Domingo>

Claro / Altice - local fixed internet services

<https://www.claro.com.do/> ; <https://www.altice.com.do/>

Weather forecast: live forecast checked 11 Sep 2026 for Santo Domingo, covering 12-18 Sep.